Chapter 25

‘We Are Orphaned’: Tihar after Kiran

APPREHENSIONS THAT THE CORRECTIONAL REFORMS THAT WERE TAKING place in Tihar and the openness that the jail was being subjected to would last only till such time that the dynamic and innovative incumbent to the post of its inspector general remained there were proven to be true in a short space of time after Kiran’s transfer. The inmates had, at the outset, expressed these very doubts when they had claimed that they had only one fear: that of having the old system come back with a vengeance. Soon, the earlier regime started rearing its ugly head.

A case in point related to the biscuit tycoon Rajan Pillai.

Regarding the tragic death of Rajan Pillai in judicial custody, Kiran expressed her feelings rather strongly:

> I am agonized. Agonized over the manner in which people have been taken for a ride yet again. An announcement of a magisterial enquiry into the circumstances of Rajan Pillai’s death on 7 July 1995 in jail is really no big deal. It is mandatory under the rules. So what is the announcement all about? What the medical causes are can be commented upon only by experts in the profession; I can certainly tell you from my managerial experience at Tihar that this jail has been a victim of apathetic governance. Tragedies of these kinds totally expose the system once in a while, and the administration only waits for some other sensational event to overshadow the present one, with public memory being short.
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> Tihar Jail has all along been grossly inadequate as far as health services are concerned. Time and again all the ‘provisioners’ not providers – for the latter is a very respectable term for those who do exercise responsibility – never cared to respond. They have been treating this prison, crammed with thousands of hapless deviants, with apathy. The poor die a quiet death. It’s only cases like those of the high-profile Rajan Pillai that expose the cheapness with which life is treated in there. To underscore my earlier point: an enquiry is mandatory. It is not required to be ‘ordered’. So what’s special? It could be special if an enquiry had been ordered to look into the following fundamental questions:
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> (1) Since when have the doctors’ vacancies not been filled?
> (2) And pray why?
> (3) Who all are the persons whose responsibility it was to do so?
> (4) Even if directions had been given, whose responsibility was it to ensure that these are fulfilled?
> (5) Isn’t regular review of coordination called for of organizational functioning where the direct